the disruption of the only disciplined force which can maintain law and order, they may yet consent to make a further contribution to the upkeep of the South Persia Rifles after 31 March.[42]

Like many in the Home government, Armitage-Smith failed to understand the Indian government's perspective on Britain's Persian relations. As long as the Persian government and people were not overtly anti-British to the point of becoming a threat, and as long as the southern and south eastern borders were relatively stable, Chelmsford and his colleagues were unconcerned with the internal state of that country, particularly if such a concern required expenditure of Indian resources – financial or military. This had been made clear in the original Eastern Committee debates in late 1918, and was perhaps the most consistently held view within the British government in this period.

As is hinted at in Armitage-Smith's statement, the arguments over the maintenance of the SPRs represented a wider issue for Britain's position in Persia at this time. One of the main reasons others had acquiesced to Curzon's plans for Persia in 1919 is that many were willing to defer to the foreign secretary's apparent knowledge of that country. Now that it had become apparent what maintaining a significant presence in Persia was really costing the British government – both financially and in terms of reputation – withdrawal was advocated.

Some British officials now began to believe that if they did not have the military and economic means to hold onto a position in the north of that country, then they might as well cut their losses and concentrate their limited resources in the south. Churchill gave a good summary of this view in February 1921:

The withdrawal [of Norperforce] from Persia leading to the loss of the Northern part of Persia may be attended by the moving of the capital from Teheran [sic] to Ispahan. This is surely very much in our interest, but it is impossible unless the South Persian Rifles are maintained...It might indeed